CHAPTER 8

IRRITANTS AND IMPEDIMENTS

These strategies and policies at times worked but overall did not perform consistently. The drone effects, the flared up Pashtun sentiments, myths and conspiracy theories – genuine or manufactured – increased gradually. Resultantly, the desired results could not be achieved.

PASHTUN NATURE

History is full of lessons to be learnt about Pashtuns' religious and tribal sensibilities, that can get triggered quite quickly. *Badal* (revenge) is the first and greatest commandment of '*Pukhtunwali*', 'the way of the Pathan' or 'the Pathan (Pashtun) code' (Spain, 1962).

Secondly, Pashtuns are devout Muslims who revere, practice and preserve Islam according to their martial nature. The American diplomat James Spain, who served in Pakistan in the 1950s, commented that 'The warrior-bishop of the Middle Ages frequently finds his counterpart among the hill pathans'. Many of the ferocious revolts against the British were led by mullahs preaching Jihad against the government of unbelievers. The notorious Fakir of Ipi, for 30 years, defied first the British and then the Pakistani governments from his cliffside headquarters in Waziristan (Spain, 1962).

TTP, mainly dominated by Pashtuns, although comprising a fraction of the entire Pashtun population, had been exploiting the Pashtun nature of revenge and religiosity. They thrived on the themes of fight against the foreign power (US) and later included the army and the government of Pakistan. The challenge before them was the imposition